

Ten minutes’ walk to green space?

Testing Labour’s 2026 green-space pledge against open population and map data

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“Every person ... no more than ten minutes’ walk from an open or green space.”

Partit Laburista, manifesto 2026, priority 19 (our translation).

Now a government commitment: Labour won the election of 30 May 2026.

VERDICT: NOT SUBSTANTIATED

No definition or baseline: met already, or far off

TL;DR

Before the general election of 30 May 2026 [9], **Labour** (now in government) promised that nobody would live more than **ten minutes' walk from an open or green space**. We tested whether the pledge has a baseline, a definition and a counting method that would let anyone check it, and measured how far Malta is from it today under each reading.

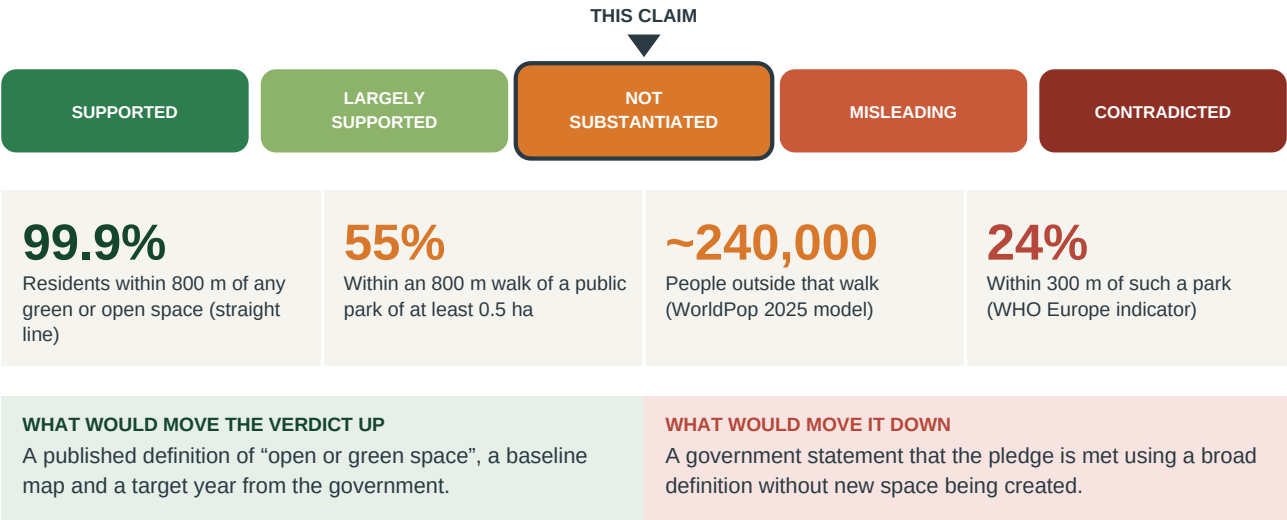
- 1

The pledge may already be met, or be far off. It depends on the definition. If any open or green space counts, about 99.9% of residents already live within 800 m. If only public parks of at least 0.5 ha count, 55–68% do, leaving some 170,000–240,000 people outside.
- 2

The manifesto gives no definition, baseline or date. Without them the pledge cannot be checked, and could be declared met without any new green space.
- 3

The WHO-style measure is far off. About a quarter of residents live within 300 m of a public park of at least 0.5 ha, the distance and size WHO Europe suggests as an indicator.
- 4

Verdict: not substantiated. The pledge is not wrong; it is not stated in a way that can be measured.



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1 The pledge and what we could verify

Our candidate record took the pledge from a MaltaToday summary [3]. We then found Labour’s own text [1], in Maltese. The translation is ours; the original wording is quoted so readers can check it. It differs from the news summary in a way that matters: it says *open or green* space, not green space.

Source	What it says (our translation)	Our access	Status
Partit Laburista, manifesto <i>Int Malta</i> , 2026, priority 19, p. 17 [1]	“Kull persuna f’pajjiżna ma tkunx aktar minn għaxar minuti mixi ‘l bogħod minn spazju miftuħ jew aħdar.” <i>Every person in our country will be no more than ten minutes’ walk from an open or green space.</i> On p. 21 the indicator is “access to open spaces and the availability of recreational zones”, to be met through green spaces within ten minutes’ walk and investment in Manoel Island, White Rocks, Fort Campbell and other parks.	Read: pp. 17 and 21 of the 268-page PDF (hash recorded).	The pledge
MaltaToday, May 2026 [3]	“every citizen is within a 10-minute walk of a green space”.	Read (Wayback copy).	Summary

FAIRNESS NOTE
Labour won the general election of 30 May 2026 [9], so its pledge is now a government commitment. The goal is legitimate: nearby green space is associated with better health [5]. The opposition PN proposes a Parks Act to give “park” and “green space” a legal definition [2], which would address part of the problem identified here. This check is about whether the pledge can be measured. The PN’s own environmental pledge for Gozo, assessed here until version 1.1, is now Claim Check 107.

2 Method

Question. Does the pledge have a definition, baseline and counting method that would allow it to be checked, and how far is Malta from it today under each reading?

Green-space access. We overlaid WorldPop’s 2025 population grid (100 m cells, constrained to built-up areas) with OpenStreetMap green and open spaces downloaded on 2 October 2026 [7]. For six definitions, from strict (public parks of at least 1 ha) to broad (any green or open space, including squares and beaches), we computed the share of residents within 300 m, 615 m and 800 m in a straight line. A ten-minute walk at 4.8 km/h is 800 m along streets; 615 m in a straight line allows for typical detours (factor 1.3). 300 m is the WHO Europe indicator distance [4]. Code: [tools/cc-011-report/green_access.py](#).

Grades. WHO guidance, meta-analyses of observational studies and official statistics are C; our own analysis is a screening estimate and is labelled as such.

3 Why the definition decides the answer

The pledge rests on a phrase that is not defined: *open or green space*. Does a paved square count, a strip of roadside grass, a patch of garrigue, a beach? The research on green space and health uses many different access measures and they do not give the same answers [4, 6]. WHO Europe proposes a minimum size (0.5 ha, with 1 ha as an additional indicator) and a short distance (300 m) precisely because tiny or distant spaces are used less [4].

4

Ten minutes from green space

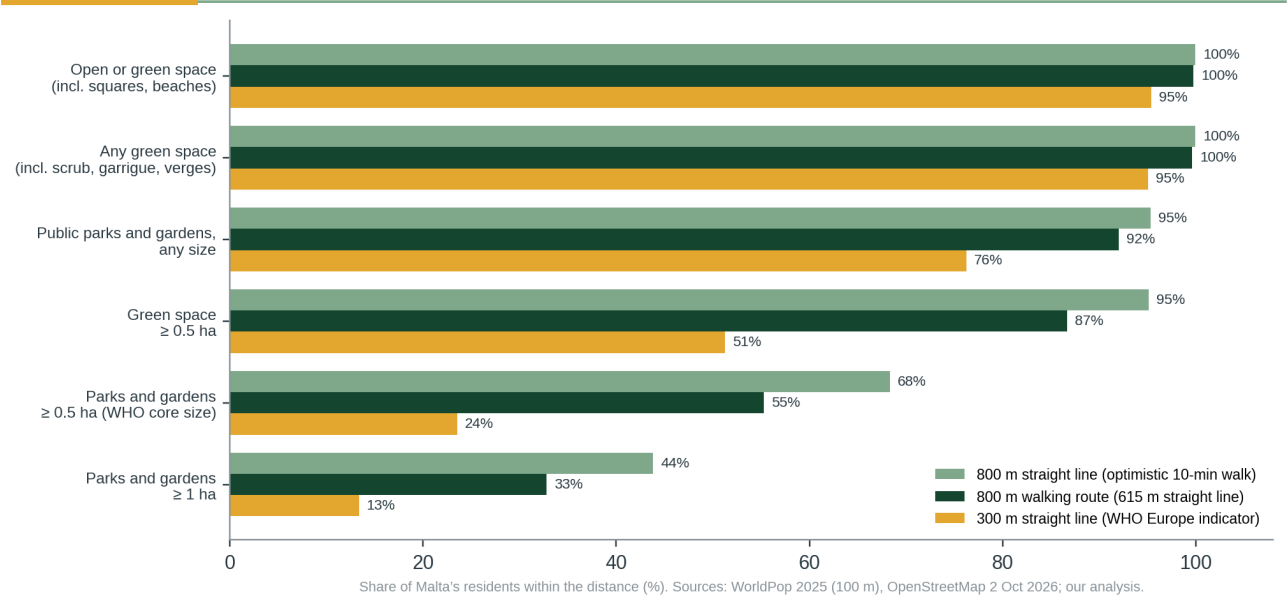


Figure 1. Share of Malta's residents within each distance of a green or open space, under six definitions. Straight-line distances overstate access; OpenStreetMap may miss or misclassify spaces. Screening estimate, not a network analysis.

Definition	Within 800 m walk (615 m line)	Residents outside	Within 300 m (WHO)
Any open or green space, incl. squares and beaches	99.7%	about 1,400	95%
Any green space, incl. scrub, garrigue, grass verges	99.6%	about 1,900	95%
Public parks and gardens, any size	92%	about 43,000	76%
Green space of at least 0.5 ha	87%	about 72,000	51%
Public parks and gardens of at least 0.5 ha	55%	about 243,000	24%
Public parks and gardens of at least 1 ha	33%	about 365,000	13%

Population base: WorldPop 2025, 542,820 residents (lower than NSO's 574,250 because the grid is a model). Full results in [data/cc-011/green_access_results.csv](#).

What this means for the pledge

- **Read broadly, the pledge is already almost met.** On the manifesto's own words ("open or green"), fewer than 2,000 modelled residents are more than a ten-minute walk from some qualifying space. The pledge could be declared fulfilled without creating anything.
- **Read as the WHO-style measure, it is far off.** Only about a quarter of residents live within 300 m of a public park of at least 0.5 ha, and about 55% within a realistic ten-minute walk of one.
- **The manifesto's own examples** (Manoel Island, White Rocks, Fort Campbell) are large parks on the edges of the built-up area, which suggests a stricter reading than "any open space". That is our inference; the manifesto does not say.

5

Testing the pledge

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Nobody more than ten minutes' walk from an open or green space	Labour [1]	No definition, baseline or year. Broad reading: about 99.7% already within reach. Strict reading: about 55%.	NO BASELINE
B. Delivered through green spaces within ten minutes and parks such as Manoel Island, White Rocks, Fort Campbell	Labour [1]	Named projects are real proposals; their effect on access depends on location. Not modelled here.	NOT TESTED
C. Related pledge in the same manifesto: a 40% cut in carbon emissions by 2030 vs 2005 (priority 18)	Labour [1]	Same aim as the Climate Action Authority's; scope not stated. See CC-003.	SEE CC-003

6

Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

The pledge lacks the definition and baseline needed to check it. Confidence: moderate. Our access analysis is a screening estimate.

Why. The pledge can be read as already achieved or as needing new parks within reach of about 240,000 people; the manifesto does not say which. A pledge is not a statement of fact, so we do not call it false; we rate it *Not substantiated* because, as worded, it cannot be shown to be achieved or missed.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say the goal is undesirable, or that anyone acted in bad faith. A checkable version of the pledge would read: “By [year], every resident will live within 800 m by foot of a public park of at least [size]; today [X]% do (map published).”

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ From the government: the definition of “open or green space” used for priority 19 (minimum size, public access, whether squares, beaches and verges count).
- ☐ From the government: the baseline share of residents within ten minutes, the method (walking network or straight line) and the target year.
- ☐ From the government: the scope of the 40% emissions cut in priority 18 (total or effort-sharing emissions).

RIGHT OF REPLY

Before wider circulation this draft should be sent to the Partit Laburista and, as the pledge is now a government commitment, the Office of the Prime Minister or the responsible ministry, with a fixed deadline (suggested 14 days). Responses will be appended and the verdict revisited.

7 Limitations

- The access analysis uses straight-line distances, a modelled population grid and OpenStreetMap tags, whose completeness in Malta we did not validate. Private gardens were excluded where tagged as private; some may remain. Grass verges and road islands are included in the broad definitions. A walking-network analysis would give lower shares for every definition.
- The manifesto translation is ours. The Labour PDF was read at pp. 17 and 21 only; other chapters may add detail.
- We read the green-space health literature [5, 6] as abstracts or metadata only; it is context for why the pledge matters, not evidence for the verdict.

References

- [1] Partit Laburista (2026). *Int Malta: Manifest Elettorali* 2026. Priorities list p. 17; indicators p. 21. SHA-256 466a60f9... recorded in literature/CC-011/references.bib. https://partitlaburista.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/08/Manifest_Elettorali_INT_MALTA_2026.pdf
- [2] Partit Nazzjonalista (2026). *Nifs Ġdid: Programm Elettorali*, chapter Ambjent (Parks Act). <https://pn.org.mt/en/nifsgdid/ambjent/>
- [3] MaltaToday (May 2026). Labour publishes its manifesto: here is a breakdown. https://www.maltatoday.com.mt/news/election-2026/141840/labour_publishes_its_manifesto_here_is_a_breakdown
- [4] WHO Regional Office for Europe (2016). *Urban green spaces and health: a review of evidence*. Copenhagen. (Indicator section read.) <https://www.who.int/europe/publications/i/item/WHO-EURO-2016-3352-43111-60341>
- [5] Twohig-Bennett C., Jones A. (2018). The health benefits of the great outdoors: a systematic review and meta-analysis of greenspace exposure and health outcomes. *Environmental Research* 166:628–637. doi:10.1016/j.envres.2018.06.030. (Abstract read.) <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.envres.2018.06.030>
- [6] Ekkel E.D., de Vries S. (2017). Nearby green space and human health: evaluating accessibility metrics. *Landscape and Urban Planning* 157:214–220. doi:10.1016/j.landurbplan.2016.06.008. (Metadata only; cited for the existence of competing metrics.) <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.landurbplan.2016.06.008>
- [7] WorldPop (2025). Malta constrained population 2025, 100 m, R2025A v1. CC BY 4.0. OpenStreetMap contributors, data via Overpass API, 2 Oct 2026, ODbL. https://data.worldpop.org/GIS/Population/Global_2015_2030/R2025A/2025/MLT/v1/100m/constrained/
- [8] Miżien. Analysis code and outputs: tools/cc-011-report/; data/cc-011/.
- [9] IFES ElectionGuide. Malta: Maltese House of Representatives 2026 General (held 30 May 2026; results source: Electoral Commission of Malta). Accessed 5 Oct 2026. <https://electionguide.org/elections/id/5161/>

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. Our own analyses are screening estimates.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** before wider circulation and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2 Oct 2026	First issue, covering two pledges (Labour’s ten-minute green space and the PN’s net-zero Gozo). Claims restated from the parties’ own texts rather than news summaries. Draft pending right of reply.
1.1	5 Oct 2026	Corrections: the flyer said that, read broadly, the pledge “is met today”; it now says “already almost met”, as the report does (a screening estimate). The unsourced seat count (“36 seats to 29”) is removed; the 30 May 2026 election is now sourced. Verdict and confidence unchanged.
1.2	5 Oct 2026	Split at the maintainer’s request: this check now covers Labour’s ten-minute pledge only, under the title “Ten minutes’ walk to green space”. The PN’s net-zero Gozo pledge and its arithmetic are now Claim Check 107. Labour’s analysis and numbers are unchanged; references renumbered. Verdict and confidence unchanged.